

► VERIFIED CHRONOLOGICAL EVIDENCE

1500 BCE

● Rigveda composed.
No Buddha.
No avatar concept. No temples.

800 BCE

● Upanishads written.
Still zero Buddha mention.

550 BCE

● Lumbini shrine built.
Oldest Buddhist structure.
Durham Univ confirmed.

268 BCE

● Ashoka converts.
Buddhism reaches Egypt, Afghanistan, Sri Lanka.

108 CE

● Mundeshwari Temple.
Oldest Hindu stone temple.
658 yrs after Lumbini.

400–500 CE

● Vishnu Purana written.
Buddha appears as "Mayamoha" — divine deception.

1193 CE

● Nalanda destroyed.
Greatest Buddhist library burned by Bakhtiyar Khilji.

1956 CE

● Ambedkar converts.
"Buddha as Vishnu = sheer madness and false propaganda"

✓ CONFIRMED 2013



Lumbini Maya Devi Temple · Nepal

ARCHAEOLOGICAL EVIDENCE · 550 BCE

Lumbini Shrine — Oldest Buddhist Structure

Durham University / Antiquity Journal · 2013

Confirmed ~550 BCE by radiocarbon dating. The oldest confirmed Buddhist structure — 658 years older than the oldest Hindu stone temple.

[UNESCO GALLERY →](#) [MORE IMAGES →](#)

THE CRITICAL TEXTUAL GAP

TEXT	DATE	BUDDHA?
Rigveda	1500 BCE	✗ NONE
Upanishads	800 BCE	✗ NONE
Bhagavad Gita	200 BCE	✗ NONE
Vishnu Purana	400 CE	✓ FIRST

TEXTUAL EVIDENCE · CRITICAL FINDING

900 Years of Silence — Then Suddenly an Avatar

"Hindus came to regard the Buddha as an avatar of Vishnu between AD 450 and the sixth century"
— Wendy Doniger, University of Chicago

[WIKIPEDIA · GAUTAMA BUDDHA IN HINDUISM →](#)

ARCHAEOLOGICAL · 3RD CENTURY BCE

Sanchi Great Stupa — Ashoka's Monument

Madhya Pradesh, India · UNESCO World Heritage

Built by Emperor Ashoka. Expanded by the Shunga dynasty (the same rulers often accused of destroying Buddhist sites — they actually preserved Sanchi).

[UNESCO GALLERY →](#) [WIKIMEDIA IMAGES →](#)

OLDEST HINDU TEMPLE · CE

Mundeshwari Temple — Oldest Surviving Hindu Temple

Bihar, India · Archaeological Survey of India confirmed

108 CE — the oldest confirmed Hindu stone temple. Built 658 years after the Lumbini Buddhist shrine. The architectural gap is real and verified.

[WIKIMEDIA IMAGES →](#) [ASI OFFICIAL →](#)

GLOBAL SPREAD · 1ST–3RD CENTURY CE

Gandhara Buddha — Greek–Buddhist Fusion Art

Pakistan / Afghanistan · Metropolitan Museum Collection

Buddhism reached Central Asia via the Silk Road centuries before Hinduism had comparable international presence. Greek artistic style merged with Buddhist iconography.

[MET MUSEUM OPEN COLLECTION →](#)
[BRITISH MUSEUM →](#)

KNOWLEDGE DESTRUCTION · 1193 CE

Nalanda University Ruins

Bihar, India · UNESCO World Heritage Site

Greatest Buddhist university. Library burned for months by Bakhtiyar Khilji in 1193 CE. Vast Buddhist texts in philosophy, medicine and science lost. The last major institutional centre of Buddhism in India.

[UNESCO GALLERY →](#) [WIKIPEDIA →](#)

GLOBAL SPREAD · 268–232 BCE

Ashoka Pillar — First Evidence of World Religion

Vaishali, India · 3rd Century BCE

Ashoka's edicts spread Buddhism to Sri Lanka, Egypt, Afghanistan and the Hellenistic kingdoms — centuries before Hinduism established comparable global networks.

[WIKIMEDIA IMAGES →](#) [UNESCO →](#)

THE PRINT · VERIFIED ARTICLE



"How Hinduism Incorporated Buddha and then Distanced the Religion"

BEST ARTICLE ON THIS TOPIC · THE PRINT

Covers the Puranic strategy of absorbing Buddha as an avatar, the temple conversion cases, the political motivations, and why Buddhism nearly disappeared from India. Based on academic

sources with real citations.

"The adoption of the Buddha was a way to absorb Buddhism in a peaceful manner, both to win Buddhists to Vaishnavism and to account for the fact that such a significant heresy could exist in India." — Helmuth von Glasenapp

READ FULL ARTICLE ON THE PRINT →

DEVDUTT PATTANAIAK · SCHOLAR

"Is Buddha an Avatar of Vishnu?"

The most-read Hindu mythologist explains the absorption strategy

HINDU SCHOLAR · DEVDUTT.COM

Even Hindu scholars acknowledge this was a strategic move. Pattanaik explains how Puranic Hinduism reframed itself in response to Buddhism's success — adopting devotionalism, temple-building and non-violence.

READ ARTICLE →

PRIMARY SOURCE · DN · 1956

B.R. Ambedkar — The Definitive Rejection

India's Constitution Drafter · Converted with 600,000 Dalits

"I do not and shall not believe that Lord Buddha was the incarnation of Vishnu. I believe this to be sheer madness and false propaganda." — 5th Conversion Vow

COLUMBIA UNIV ARCHIVE → WIKIPEDIA →

NAOMI KANAKIA · SUBSTACK ESSAY

"Hinduism Did Not Precede Buddhism"

The clearest non-academic explanation of the scholarly consensus

BEST LONG-FORM ESSAY · VERIFIED LINK

Explains why the term "Hinduism" didn't even exist in its modern sense during Buddha's time, and how the Vedic priestly tradition was fundamentally different from the devotional Hinduism practiced today.

READ FULL ESSAY →

GLOBAL REACH · 5TH-6TH CENTURY CE

Bamiyan Buddhas — Before & After Destruction

Afghanistan · Carved 5th-6th Century CE · Destroyed by Taliban 2001

Built centuries before comparable Hindu monuments reached Central Asia. Proof of Buddhism's extraordinary global spread. Destroyed by Taliban in 2001 — one of history's great acts of cultural erasure.

WIKIMEDIA IMAGES → WIKIPEDIA →

WIKIPEDIA · WELL SOURCED

"Buddhism and Hinduism"

Most comprehensive starting point with real academic footnotes

REFERENCE ARTICLE · USE FOOTNOTES

Covers the entire 2,500-year relationship — competition, coexistence, absorption. Each claim has numbered citations linking to real academic sources. Use the footnotes to find primary scholarship.

WIKIPEDIA · BUDDHISM AND HINDUISM →

THE BUDDHA IN HINDUISM →

Final Scholarly Verdict — What Is Confirmed vs. What Is Not

✓ Buddhist structures predate Hindu temples by 658 years

Lumbini 550 BCE vs Mundeshwari 108 CE — archaeologically confirmed.

✓ Buddha not mentioned in any Veda

Complete silence across all four Vedas, Upanishads, and the Bhagavad Gita.

✓ Avatar theory appears 900+ years after Buddha died

Vishnu Purana ~400-500 CE. Called "Mayamoha" — a divine deception, not a celebration.

✓ Buddhism spread globally before Hinduism

Ashoka's mission: Egypt, Afghanistan, Sri Lanka — all 3rd century BCE.

✗ "Buddhism came before ALL Hindu traditions"

The Rigveda (~1500 BCE) predates Buddhism. The Vedic tradition is older.

✗ "All Hindu temples built on Buddhist sites"

Some documented cases exist. The Shungas actually preserved Sanchi.

PEER-REVIEWED JOURNAL

Antiquity Journal — Lumbini 2013

antiquity.ac.uk/ant/087/ant0870042.htm

ACADEMIC BOOK

Wendy Doniger — The Hindus

books.google.com → search "Hindus Alternative History Doniger"

ACADEMIC BOOK

Richard Gombrich — What the Buddha Thought

books.google.com → search "What Buddha Thought Gombrich"

FREE ACADEMIC SEARCH

Google Scholar

UNESCO HERITAGE

Lumbini — Official Gallery

PRIMARY SOURCE

Ambedkar Writings — Columbia Univ

[scholar.google.com → "buddha vishnu avatar puranas"](https://scholar.google.com/?hl=en&q=buddha+vishnu+avatar+puranas)

whc.unesco.org/en/list/666/gallery/

columbia.edu/itc/mealac/pritchett/00ambedkar/

MUSEUM COLLECTION

Metropolitan Museum — Open Access

[metmuseum.org → Gandhara Buddha \(open access\)](https://metmuseum.org/gandhara/Buddha)

REDDIT RESEARCH

r/AskHistorians — Buddhism & Hinduism

reddit.com/r/AskHistorians → "Buddhism older Hinduism"

VERIFIED ARTICLE

Smarthistory — Buddhism & Hinduism

smarthistory.org/hinduism-and-buddhism-an-introduction/